FOR OLLY

Sharpen your French and Italian

A short guide to a set of free practice apps written for French, Italian and Spanish teaching. Every blue link below opens the right app. No login, nothing to install, and it works on a laptop or a phone.

The idea in one minute

Each app is a fast, self-marked drill. A card appears and is read aloud. You say the answer, press Show Answer, and press one of three keys: ← major error, ↓ nearly, → got it. Cards you miss come back until you know them. A drill of 20 cards takes about five minutes.

The point is **finding the gaps**. Even strong students find holes in the things that were never drilled: vocabulary and genders, the exact irregular forms, the small grammar points. Be strict with the marking and the gaps show up quickly.

> **Careful** **Do not be fooled by the word "IGCSE".** Many of these apps carry that label, and it is easy to think "that will be too easy for me". It is not. They contain **a great deal that you do not know well enough to dismiss**: gender and plural of ordinary nouns, small words and prepositions, the exact irregular forms of verbs, and the grammar points that never quite stuck. Take the label as a description of the exam board, not of how hard the drill will feel. **Try a drill before you decide.**

Your first 30 minutes: three links

1. Italian verbs (10 minutes)

▶️ **Open Birley Italian Verbs**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20Italian%20Verbs.html

- Under **Verb set** choose **IGCSE verbs**. Under **Mode** choose **Full (6 forms)**.
- Under **Tenses** tick **Past Hist.**, **Pres. Subj.** and **Imp. Subj.** only. Under **Regularity** choose **Irregular**.
- Press ▶️ **Start Drill**. Say all six forms aloud before pressing Show All Forms.

2. French verbs (10 minutes)

▶️ **Open Birley French Verbs**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20French%20Verbs.html

- Under **Verb set** choose **Specialist**. Under **Mode** choose **Full (6 forms)**.
- Under **Tenses** choose **All Tenses**, so that you meet the subjunctive too.
- Press ▶️ **Start Drill**.

3. Italian grammar (10 minutes)

▶️ **Open Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs (then press 📘 Gr EWs, then 🇮🇹 Italian)**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Vocab%20and%20Gr%20EWs.html

- Choose chapter **13**, then ▶️ **Start Drill**. Chapters 13 to 15 are the present, perfect and imperfect subjunctive, **se** and **come se**, the passive and the future and conditional perfect.
- Say or write the Italian before you look. Items are rules, translations and transformations.

The 60-second test: no peeking

Italian	French
Passato remoto, **io**: bere, sapere, volere, rimanere, dire	Subjonctif: que je ___ (valoir), (craindre), (acquérir), (cueillir)
Translate: "If it was up to me, I would choose to spend the summer holidays in Sicily." (up to me = dipendere da)	Futur, **je**: cueillir, acquérir, mourir
Translate: "The more I think about it, the more I find that history is much more interesting than geography."	Say aloud in French: **however rich you are**, and **no sooner had they left than the baby started crying**

Answers are on the last page.

Part 1. Italian

> **Careful** **Do not be fooled by the word "IGCSE".** Many of these apps carry that label, and it is easy to think "that will be too easy for me". It is not. They contain **a great deal that you do not know well enough to dismiss**: gender and plural of ordinary nouns, small words and prepositions, the exact irregular forms of verbs, and the grammar points that never quite stuck. Take the label as a description of the exam board, not of how hard the drill will feel. **Try a drill before you decide.**

Italian is where the apps can help you most. There are five good ways in. Start with the first two.

1.1 Verbs: the irregular forms you can never quite hold

▶️ **Open Birley Italian Verbs**

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20Italian%20Verbs.html

- **115 IGCSE verbs**, with 11 tenses for most. The drill offers Present, Future, Perfect, Imperfect, Conditional, **Pres. Subj.**, **Imp. Subj.**, **Past Hist.** (passato remoto) and Infinitive. Pluperfect, Future perfect and Conditional perfect appear in the tests.
- Rarer irregulars are all there: bere (bevvi, berrò, beva, bevessi), rimanere, rompersi, venire, volere, dovere, scegliere, spegnere, togliersi, costringere.
- Set **Regularity** to **Irregular**. Use **Full (6 forms)** to say a whole tense, or **Single form** for speed.
- 🧩 **AP Advanced Verb Structures** has about 585 set phrases conjugated in every tense, such as "assestare un duro colpo a X", "andare in estasi per X" and "per quanto ricco tu sia".
- Use 💬 **Sentences** for gap-fill sentences with the verb in context.

Why it helps: You see the verb, the person and the tense, and you have to produce the form from memory, which is exactly what a university test does.

1.2 Grammar: 15 chapters, from articles to the subjunctive

▶️ **Open Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs**

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Vocab%20and%20Gr%20EWs.html

- Open the page, press 📘 **Gr EWs**, then 🇮🇹 **Italian**. There are **750 items**: rules, translations and transformations. Do not skip the early chapters: **1 to 10** hold the points that cost marks quietly.
- Chapters **11 to 15** are the most demanding: **11** combined pronouns and the imperative, **12** relative pronouns and the pluperfect, **13** present and perfect subjunctive, **14** imperfect subjunctive and **se + conditional**, **15** the passive, future perfect, conditional perfect and **ecco + pronouns**.
- Chapters **1 to 10** cover articles, plurals and irregular nouns, articulated prepositions, partitives, **ne** and **ci**, **piacere**, **avere or essere**, participle agreement, comparatives and negatives.
- Tick two or more chapters (**combo mode**) to mix them. Press 📝 **Generate Test**, or ⏱️ **AP Spot Test: timed & submitted** (choose **Untimed** if you like), to test yourself.
- Press **Grammar recaps: pick one or several**. On the picker page you can search, **Tick all**, or tick a group, then press **Read ↓**, **Print** or **Save as PDF**. Read chapters **13, 14 and 15 together** in one sitting: the subjunctive, **se + conditional** and the passive are exactly where an A* student still slips.
- Each recap ends with **"Soon I will be able to…"** and a tickable **"Now I can…"** checklist (about 9 to 12 statements per chapter). Say or write your own example for each statement, press **Check** to see the model answer, then tick it. Ticks are saved on that device only.

- Hard items include: "Se ne avessi l'occasione, sceglierei di studiare a Roma per un anno" and "Tom ha detto che sarebbe venuto" (the conditional perfect for a future seen from the past).

Why it helps: The chapters are built from the points that learners most often get wrong, and every point is tested several ways.

1.3 Vocabulary: the 2,000 words everything else rests on

▶️ Open Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Vocab%20and%20Gr%20EWs.html

- On the same page press 📚 **IGCSE Vocab**. Press 📚 **Choose lists** and tick **IGCSE Nouns** (1,108), **IGCSE Verbs** (450), **IGCSE Adjectives** (193) and **IGCSE Prep/Conj/Adv** (219).
- Under **Direction** set English on the left and Italian on the right, then press ⇄ **Swap** and do it the other way too.
- Tick **Hard** under **Level**. About 1,165 of the 1,970 core Italian words are Hard (nothing like the English, no clue), which is where the gaps hide. Then do Medium and Easy as well: do not assume you know them.
- Answers show the gender and useful extras, for example "l'arte (f) (l'artista (m/f), artistico/a)". Check yours.
- The E and D lists (E Mich Voc 2 to 10, D Lent Voc and so on) are the same words in smaller slices, useful when you have ten minutes.

Why it helps: Gender, articles and the small words (prepositions, conjunctions, adverbs) are where marks are quietly lost.

1.4 Speaking and writing: structures that make you sound Italian

▶️ Open Birley IGCSE Structures & Oral
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Birley%20Structures%20%26%20Oral%20and%20Writing%20Practice.html

- Press 📚 **AP Structures**. There are 1,490 sentence pairs in 77 sections, in English and Italian. The opinion sections have the best phrases.
- Samples: "Rispetto al calcio, il tennis è molto più rilassante." · "Se dovessi scegliere io, direi che la storia è più interessante della geografia." · "È solo allenandosi ogni giorno che si può migliorare nel tennis." · "Più ci rifletto, più mi sembra che viaggiare all'estero sia il modo migliore per ampliare i propri orizzonti."
- Then press 🎙️ **AP Oral Exam Practice**, choose 🇮🇹 **Italian**, and ✔ **Real past papers only**. There are 115 cards. Open a card and press 🎧 **Demo Mode** for a model answer with 🎤 **Karaoke text**, then press ✍️ **Translate 10 sentences** to write your own.

Why it helps: You get ready-made, natural sentences with the structures marked, and then you have to use them.

1.5 Discourse and idioms: sounding fluent rather than correct

▶️ Open Birley A Level Oral Phrase Bank
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20Oral%20Phrase%20Bank.html

- The **Oral Phrase Bank** has 309 phrases in English, French, Italian and Spanish. Choose **Concessions / Nuances** and **H: Hypothesis** in **Category**.
- Samples: "Detto questo", "Anche a costo di INF", "Resta il fatto che", "Nella misura in cui", "Comunque sia", "Per quanto ADJ sia X", "Mettendomi nei panni di X, penso che", "Se dipendesse da me decidere, sceglierei di".
- Then try **Birley Essential Phrases** (link below): Levels 5 and 6 are idioms, such as "alla lettera", "entrare da un orecchio ed uscire dall'altro" and "scontrarsi con un muro".

Why it helps: Link words and idioms are what make written and spoken Italian sound natural.

▶️ Open Birley Essential Phrases

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20Gen%20Essential%20Phrases.html

> **Tip** **Easy wins:** press ☕ **Leisure Mode** on any of these and the cards play by themselves, question then answer, with no marking. Good for walking to a lecture. Use ⚡ **AP Speed Challenge** with a flatmate for a competitive game.

1.6 Listening: six real Cambridge papers (try one cold)

▶️ Open Birley IGCSE Italian Listening

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Italian%20Listening.html

- Open **Birley IGCSE Italian Listening**. It holds six real Cambridge IGCSE Italian listening papers, **IT001 to IT006** (7164/12, 2021 to 2026), 37 questions and 40 marks each.
- Do one **cold**, with no preparation, and see what you miss. The voice is computer-generated Italian, not the original recording, so judge the content rather than the accent.
- Mark yourself, then drill the words and structures you missed in **Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs** (task 1.3).

Why it helps: Careful listening to fast, ordinary Italian shows up gaps in vocabulary and verb forms that reading never does.

Part 2. French

> **Careful** **Do not be fooled by the word "IGCSE".** Many of these apps carry that label, and it is easy to think "that will be too easy for me". It is not. They contain **a great deal that you do not know well enough to dismiss**: gender and plural of ordinary nouns, small words and prepositions, the exact irregular forms of verbs, and the grammar points that never quite stuck. Take the label as a description of the exam board, not of how hard the drill will feel. **Try a drill before you decide.**

Start with verbs and grammar. The A Level material is a step up, and the GCSE-level French (2.4) is worth checking too.

2.1 Verbs: 35 specialist verbs and 613 structures

▶️ Open Birley French Verbs

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20French%20Verbs.html

- Set **Verb set** to **Specialist**. The 35 verbs include: acquérir, naître, croître, mentir, peindre, valoir, croire, rompre, fuir, craindre, apercevoir, cueillir, joindre, enfreindre, nuire, haïr, mourir, s'asseoir, vivre, se taire, atteindre, s'essuyer, pleuvoir, résoudre, moudre, coudre, vêtir, geindre, éteindre, vaincre, découvrir, décevoir, tenir, souffrir, mettre.
- Choose **All Tenses**, Mode **Full (6 forms)**, and say the whole conjugation. The tense list goes up to the subjunctive, pluperfect, future perfect and conditional perfect.
- Then switch **Verb set** to 🧩 **AP Structures**: "au cas où (+ CONDITIONAL)", "de peur que (+ NE + SUBJ)", "à peine étaient-ils partis que le bébé a commencé à pleurer", "quelques raisons qu'il ait avancées", "il aurait mieux valu faire X".
- Do not skip the **Quizlet** set (about 100 everyday verbs in all the tenses). Everyday verbs are where slips happen.

Why it helps: The tense is chosen for you, so there is nowhere to hide on the awkward verbs.

2.2 Grammar: 20 chapters, 2,400 items, and 12 sentence sets

▶️ Open Birley A Level French VVs & Gr EWs & Translation

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20VVs%20%26%20Gr%20EWs%20%26%20Grammar%20Translation%20Practice%20and%20Drills.html

- Press the top-bar button 🏆 **Gr EWs**. The 20 chapters run from present and imperfect formation, through pronouns, negatives, the passive and relative pronouns, to the **subjunctive (chapters 15 and 16)**, **word order and inversion (17)**, articles, adjectives and adverbs.
- Under the chapter drop-down there is a bar **"Want an AP grammar recap? Gr N · title"**. Read it first. It has a colour key (rules, examples, tips and patterns, exceptions, watch out, summaries), mnemonics such as **ANPQ** and **PJRP**, and ends with **"Soon I will be able to…"** and a **"Now I can…"** checklist of 12 statements per chapter. Try to do each one before you press Check.
- Choose **Test me on: Translations only** to practise producing French, or **Rules only** for pure recall. Tick several chapters to **combine** them.
- Press 🎯 **Grammar Drills** for 12 sets of 88 sentences each: the passive, past participle agreement, the subjunctive, **si** clauses, object pronouns, relative pronouns, imparfait v passé composé, negatives, the gerund, **depuis** and **venir de**, **rendre X adj** and **faire inf**, infinitive constructions.

Why it helps: Each point is tested again and again in different sentences, so errors stand out.

2.3 Translation: into French and into English

▶️ Open Birley A Level French VVs & Gr EWs & Translation

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20VVs%20%26%20Gr%20EWs%20%26%20Grammar%20Translation%20Practice%20and%20Drills.html

- Press ✍️ **Translation Practice**. There are 122 passages. Choose **Into French** or **Into English**, then 🎲 **Random**.
- Write your translation first. Then press ▶️ **Reveal Mark Scheme**. The passage is split into 20 chunks with model answers, accepted alternatives and examiner notes. Mark each chunk yourself.

Why it helps: Close, timed translation with a mark scheme is the closest thing here to a real university translation paper.

2.4 Vocabulary and phrases: topic vocabulary, then the basics

▶️ Open Birley A Level French VVs & Gr EWs & Translation

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20VVs%20%26%20Gr%20EWs%20%26%20Grammar%20Translation%20Practice%20and%20Drills.html

- Press 📚 **VVs Drill**. About 2,850 phrases in sets VV1a to VV12c on family, education, work, music, media, festivals, immigration, the far right, the Occupation, Vichy and the Resistance. Examples: "une sous-représentation dans certains secteurs", "rejoindre le maquis", "Jamais je ne consentirai à l'aider".
- 📝 **VVs Sentence Drill** gives you the same phrases inside sentences.

▶️ Open Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs (French vocab and GCSE grammar)

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Vocab%20and%20Gr%20EWs.html

- Choose French in the **Direction** menus. You get the same core lists and levels as for Italian, plus **39 chapters of GCSE-level French grammar** under 📘 **Gr EWs**. Because it says GCSE, it is tempting to skip it. Do a few drills first: it is quick, and you will find things you have forgotten.

2.5 Background and speaking: the Oral Topics app

▶️ Open Birley A Level French Oral Topics & Paper 1

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20Oral%20Topics%20%26%20Paper%201%20Practice.html

- Press ▶️ **Open KTR Studio** first. Each of the 69 Key Topic References is a short French **story** that is read aloud (🔊 Français, English or Both), with large text, auto-play and karaoke highlighting. Then work through five stages: **Comprendre**, **Les mots** (the words and chunks), **Dire** (Recall, Gaps, Rebuild, Spot the error), **Utiliser** and **Les repères**. Some videos need an Eton sign-in.
- Press **Key Topic References Drill** for definitions, examples and analysis of 69 topics, in French, on the same 12 themes. Under **Test me on** try **Translate: full** and **Translate: short**: they make you produce the French from English.
- Press **Oral Exam Cards** to practise speaking on a card with the 🎧 **Demo Mode** model answers and 🎤 **Karaoke** text.
- Press **AP Oral Cycle Practice** for 134 phrases for structuring an answer.

Why it helps: Background facts plus polished spoken French, in the same register a university oral expects.

2.6 Link words and idioms

▶️ Open Birley A Level Oral Phrase Bank

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20Oral%20Phrase%20Bank.html

- In **Category** choose **Concessions / Nuances**. Samples: "Cela dit", "Quitte à INF", "X a beau INF", "Toujours est-il que", "Dans la mesure où", "Quoi qu'il en soit", "Si ADJ que soit X", "Bien que (quoique) + SUBJ".

- Levels 5 and 6 of **Birley Essential Phrases** (link in Part 1.5) are idioms in French as well as Italian.

A treat for a French and Italian student: compare them side by side

In the VVs app (link in 2.2), press the top-bar button 🌐 **AP Metalanguage Formulae**. There are 193 grammar patterns, each in English, French, Spanish and Italian. Set **From** to 🇫🇷 and **To** to 🇮🇹 and translate between them. Example: "Il ne fait que INF" is "Non fa altro che INF".

▶️ Open the VVs app (then press 🌐 AP Metalanguage Formulae)

https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20VVs%20%26%20Gr%20EWs%20%26%20Grammar%20Translation%20Practice%20and%20Drills.html

Part 3. A routine, and how the drills work

Five 15-minute sessions a week

Day	Task	Where
Monday	Italian verbs: irregular, passato remoto and subjunctives (20 cards, then drill the errors)	Birley Italian Verbs
Tuesday	French verbs: Specialist verbs, all tenses	Birley French Verbs
Wednesday	Italian grammar: read the recap for one chapter (13 to 15 first, then 1 to 10), drill it, then tick its "Now I can…" list	Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs
Thursday	French grammar: read the recap, do a Gr EWs chapter or Grammar Drills set, tick "Now I can…", then one translation passage	Birley A Level French VVs & Gr EWs & Translation
Friday	Vocabulary, Hard first: Italian nouns and verbs, then French	Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs
Any day	Leisure Mode while walking, Speed Challenge with a friend	any app

How a drill works

1. Open the app. Choose what to practise and press ▶️ **Start Drill**. The card is read aloud.
2. **Say the answer out loud first.** Then press **Show Answer** (or the → key).
3. Mark yourself: **× Major error (←)**, **~ Nearly (↓)** or **✓ Got it (→)**. Be strict. A missing accent is "Nearly".
4. At the end press ▶️ **Drill major errors again**. Use **Copy list** to paste your errors into Notes.

Things worth knowing

- **Sound:** the voice reading each card is your device's text-to-speech. It sounds much better with an enhanced voice installed (on a Mac or iPhone: Settings, Accessibility, Spoken Content). Tap 🔊 **Voices** in any app to check.
- **Scores are not saved.** Use Copy list to keep the cards you got wrong.
- **Ignore:** the round photo in the header, any button marked ✎ **Edit**, **Print Content** or 🔑, and the "Save my work as PDF" and OneNote steps at the end of timed tests. Those belong to AP's classes.
- **Tests:** 📝 **Generate Test** makes a printable test. ⏱️ **AP Spot Test: timed & submitted** is a short on-screen test that you mark yourself (choose **Untimed** to take it at your own pace). In a timed test, do not leave the page: a loud siren sounds.
- **Levels:** most apps have **Easy / Medium / Hard**. Easy looks like English, Medium looks like a different English word, Hard gives you nothing to go on. Start on Hard to find the gaps, then clear the rest.

All the links in one place

▶️ **Open Birley Italian Verbs**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20Italian%20Verbs.html

▶️ **Open Birley French Verbs**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20French%20Verbs.html

▶️ **Open Birley IGCSE Vocab and Gr EWs**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Vocab%20and%20Gr%20EWs.html

▶️ **Open Birley IGCSE Structures & Oral**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Birley%20Structures%20%26%20Oral%20and%20Writing%20Practice.html

▶️ **Open Birley A Level Oral Phrase Bank**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20Oral%20Phrase%20Bank.html

▶️ **Open Birley Essential Phrases**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20Gen%20Essential%20Phrases.html

▶️ **Open Birley A Level French VVs & Gr EWs & Translation**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20VVs%20%26%20Gr%20EWs%20%26%20Grammar%20Translation%20Practice%20and%20Drills.html

▶️ **Open Birley A Level French Oral Topics & Paper 1**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20A%20Level%20French%20Oral%20Topics%20%26%20Paper%201%20Practice.html

▶️ **Open Birley IGCSE Italian Listening**
https://apowles.github.io/AP/Birley%20IGCSE%20Italian%20Listening.html

Answers to the 60-second test

- **Passato remoto, io:** bevvi, seppi, volli, rimasi, dissi.
- **Italian translations:** "Se dipendesse da me, sceglierei di passare le vacanze estive in Sicilia." · "Più ci penso, più trovo che la storia sia molto più interessante della geografia."
- **Subjonctif:** que je vaille, que je craigne, que j'acquière, que je cueille.
- **Futur, je:** je cueillerai, j'acquerrai, je mourrai.
- **French structures:** "si riche que tu sois" (however rich you are) and "à peine étaient-ils partis que le bébé a commencé à pleurer" (no sooner had they left than the baby started crying).